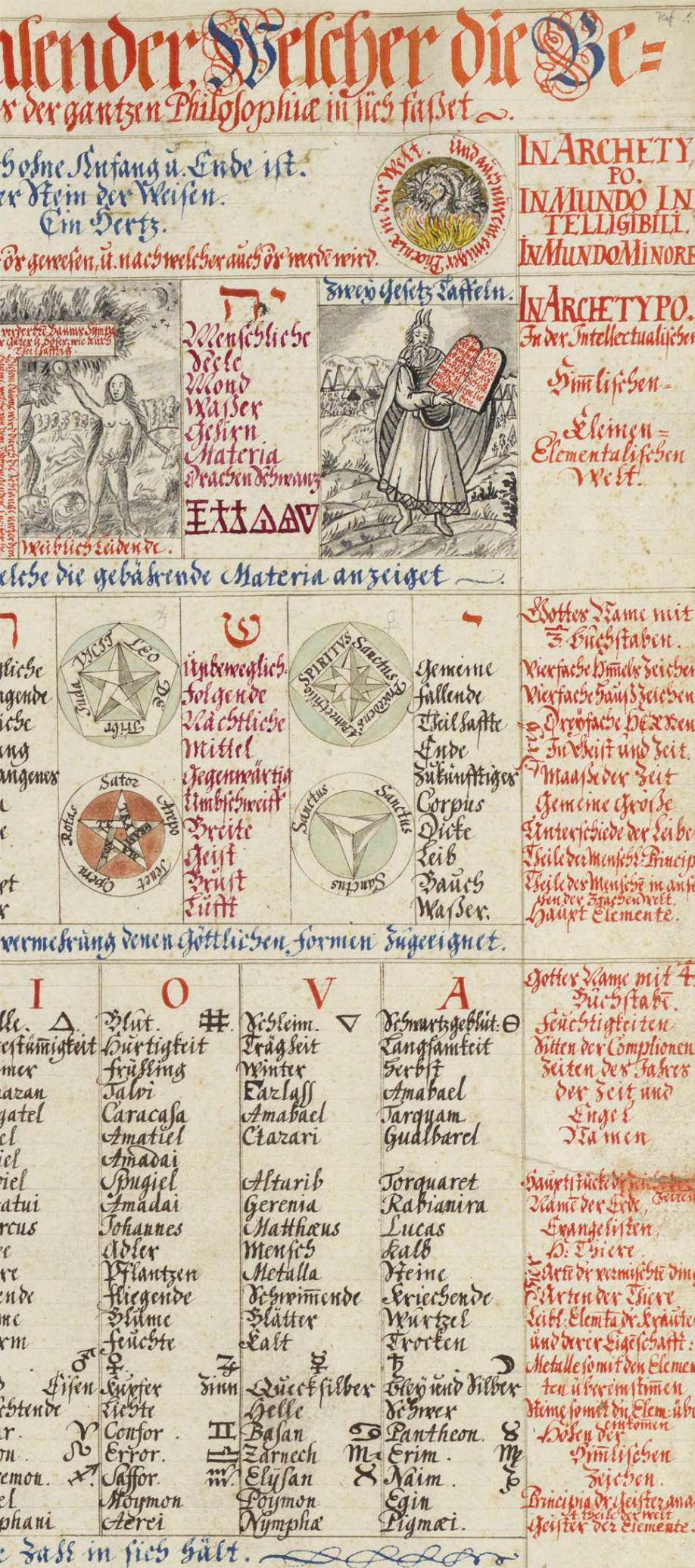




The key to all knowledge

Books of magic have a long pedigree, going back to the ancient Mesopotamian omen tablets (see p.19) and the Greek Magical Papyri (see p.32) and continuing through the medieval period. Their existence suggests a desire to make a physical record of arcane knowledge. During the Renaissance, the advent of printing made possible the wider production and dissemination of such knowledge in handbooks of magic, or grimoires (although this term did not come into common use until the 18th century). These varied from grand leather-bound volumes to scrappily bound pamphlets, but the occult knowledge within them lent the books themselves an almost magical quality.

The reputations of the more popular titles were boosted by (largely false) associations with established scholars. For example, the *Heptameron*, attributed to the 13th-century Parisian scholar Peter d'Abano, was actually first published in 1559, while the *Fourth Book of Occult Philosophy* (also published in 1559) was falsely claimed to be the work of the occult philosopher Cornelius Agrippa, who had died 24 years earlier. Most widespread of all was the *Key of Solomon*, which began to circulate in the 14th century. This book contains a hodgepodge of spells and incantations allegedly composed by the biblical King Solomon, and, based on accounts of trials by the Inquisition, it seems to have been especially common in Spain and Italy during the Renaissance.

“This book deals with ... how to evoke spirits ... to prolong life by 300 years.”

PHILIPP HOMAGIUS, ON A 1617 COPY OF THE ARBATEL, 1575